



FAMILY MEMBERS GRIEVE BESIDE GUPTA'S BODY (FAR LEFT); BSP MLA SHEKHAR TIWARI (LEFT) AND MAYAWATI CUTTING THE CAKE AT HER LAST BIRTHDAY CELEBRATIONS



SIPRA DAS

ister to meet Atiq Ahmed, Mukhtar Ansari and his brother Afzal Ansari, an SP MP, all politicians with a criminal past. She welcomed the western Uttar Pradesh don D.P. Yadav and others into the BSP. Mayawati's claims of taking on the mafia sounded hollow when she announced Arun Shankar Shukla alias Anna, a dreaded criminal, as the BSP candidate from Unnao. Having failed to woo Brahmin politicians from rival parties, she and her Man Friday found it easier to lure dons belonging to the caste. A consequence of her moves has been the 20 per cent increase in crimes in comparison to Mulayam's regime.

Dons and notorious criminals have always been a privileged class in the state just as ministers and legislators. But the opposition SP used this gruesome incident to counter Mayawati's claims of an improved law

Cashing In

- During the last assembly elections, there were charges that BSP tickets were being given to the highest bidder.
- Many BSP MLAs were allegedly indulging in extortion to recoup money spent on tickets.
- BSP ministers were known to periodically meet mafia dons in jail.
- More than half a dozen top criminal-politicians joined the BSP in the last one year.
- Dons allowed to run parallel administrations in their areas.
- More compromises likely with Lok Sabha polls in sight.

and order situation and called for a statewide *bandh*. "Mayawati will celebrate her birthday on the bodies of innocents," said Ashok Dubey, former BJP MLC from Auraiya.

The root cause is not Shekhar Tiwari or others of such ilk but the BSP's structure. Gupta's killing reflects the pressure that functionaries are under to deliver huge sums for the party coffers. "In the BSP, poll tickets are given to those who contribute Rs 50 lakh or more for her party fund. Those who don't meet the fate of Manoj Gupta," said BJP spokesman Hriday Narayan Dixit. In pursuit of her larger national ambitions, Mayawati, in the run-up to the general elections, is criss-crossing the country by trying to whip up frenzy for the BSP. Unfortunately she seems to be unaware of the damage that her minions are inflicting on her cause. ■